



AFTER

After the Civil War the cavalry became, for a time, the most prestigious and most numerous branch of the U.S. Army.

PLAINS INDIAN WARS

After the war, attention turned to **subduing American Indian tribes** on the Plains of the Western frontier. Congress authorized the U.S. Army to raise **ten cavalry units**, two of which were Black American regiments—nicknamed “buffalo soldiers.” Despite the disaster suffered by Custer’s 7th Cavalry at Little Big Horn, the U.S. cavalry finally defeated the Indians. By 1877, the **regular army contained 10,970 cavalry**, compared with fewer than 10,000 infantry.

80,000 The number of Union cavalry enrolled at the end of the Civil War. In contrast, Confederate cavalry numbered around 40,000.

FINAL FLOURISH

The last major cavalry operation was in 1916 when General Pershing pursued **Pancho Villa’s irregulars** into Mexico. By World War II, all cavalry divisions were abandoning horses to become **armored** or **mechanized formations**—later extended to the introduction of **airborne cavalry** relying on helicopters for mobility.